

hour battle, 15 US servicemen died, while 23 perished in a helicopter crash in Thailand, where troops were preparing for action.



Landing on Koh Tang

Helicopters drop Marines on Koh Tang on May 14. Intelligence had incorrectly indicated that the assault, a combined action operation involving 230 Marines, supported by USAF planes, would meet minimal resistance.

Left behind

Three Marines—in addition to the unrecovered bodies of dead servicemen—were left behind in the precarious extrication from the island, which was conducted at night under heavy fire. Not knowing the fate of the lost men, and certain that more would die in any rescue mission, the US command denied the Marines' request to return for their stranded comrades. The Khmer Rouge commander of Koh Tang later reported that one of the Marines had been captured and executed immediately afterward. The other two were also captured and subsequently killed, although accounts of the timing and circumstances differ.